Chikankari is being used for apparel as well as home products. Embroidery is done on different fabrics like crepe silks, chiffons, georgettes, and cotton-polyester blends. Traditionally white on white embroidery on white fabric was common. Modern chikankari has a wider colour palette, from pastels to bright colours.



Figure 9.29 Chikankari Embroidery

9.5.2 Chambarumal Embroidery

Region

Chambarumal, is originated from Himachal Pradesh. It dates back to 15th century. There is a mention of this embroidery being practiced in Pathankot, Chamba and other remote villages of Himachal Pradesh in Buddhist literature and the Jataka Tales. Chamba was known for the most charming needlework, which the Romans described as 'needle painting'.

Technique

The embroidery is executed on two types of unbleached cotton cloth: lightweight, delicate muslin or hand spun, hand-woven, coarser khaddar. Untwisted dyed silk threads in bright colours like red, yellow, green, blue, crimson and purple are used for the embroidery. The embroidery uses double satin stitch which simultaneously fills in the motif on both sides of the fabric. The embroidered fabric is reversible

Motifs

The motifs used are inspired by Pahari paintings depicting Lord Krishna and his playful antics. The embroidery also depicts the flora and fauna of the Himalayan region. Typical motifs include tiger, goat, deer, horse, peacock, parrot, flowers, shrubs and plants, willow and cypress trees; and musical instruments like sitar, tabla, veena, tampura etc.

Style of Embroidery

The embroidery is executed on a square piece of cloth. The motifs are arranged on the rumal in order to portray scenes from Lord Krishna's life. Some of the popular themes include Rasamandala, Rukmini Haran and Kaliyadaman. There are floral borders on all four sides of the rumal.

End Use

Traditionally the rumal was used as a case for food prasad offered to Gods and Goddesses. It was also a tradition to gift embroidered rumals at the time of weddings. Nowadays, the Chamba embroidery is made on fabrics like silk, polyester or terrycot and made into blouses, caps, slippers, cushions covers etc. Embroidered silk wall hangings are also exported from Himachal Pradesh.

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